

Marshall Willen II

A small package that packs a punch

It won't be wrong to say that the Indian market is flooded with portable Bluetooth speakers. With brands like JBL, Sony, Bose, and Marshall all competing for a slice of the market, it can be quite the task for buyers to pick the right one. Even in the ultra-portable segment, there's such a diverse range of options that figuring out which speaker gives you the best value for money is not always straightforward.

When the Marshall Willen II landed at our test centre, my first thought was to figure out where it sits in Marshall's lineup. Given that the brand has offerings at various price points, it was important to understand the Willen II's positioning. With a price tag of ₹12,499, it sits in direct competition with compact Bluetooth speakers from Sony, JBL, and Bose. So, how does it hold up?

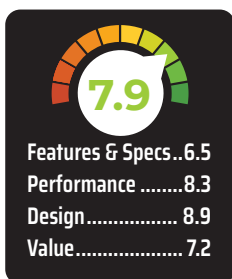
Here's how the Marshall Willen II fared in our testing and whether it justifies its price tag -

BUILD AND DESIGN

The Willen II retains Marshall's signature design language—if you've seen their speakers before, you'll know what to expect. The textured grille with the Marshall logo is instantly recognisable, and the rubberised exterior gives it a rugged yet premium feel. It's available in two colour options: Black and Brass or Cream, both of which exude vintage charm.

Despite its compact size (100.5 x 100.5 x 43.4 mm) and lightweight (0.36 kg), the speaker feels surprisingly solid. The IP67 rating ensures

₹12,499



dust and water resistance, meaning you can confidently take it outdoors without worrying about accidental splashes or dust exposure. The speaker also features a rubber strap at the back, allowing you to attach it to bike handlebars, backpack straps, or even hang it on a hook.

On the top, the speaker has a minimal control layout. A multi-directional joystick replaces traditional buttons, letting you adjust volume, play/pause tracks, and skip songs intuitively. There's also a Bluetooth pairing button and a power button. While I appreciate the simplicity, I would have liked some tactile feedback on the joystick for better control.

FEATURES

The Willen II keeps things simple when it comes to features. Connectivity is handled via Bluetooth 5.3 LE,

offering a stable connection and an impressive range of up to 100 metres in an open space. However, there's no AUX input or USB audio support, meaning you're entirely dependent on Bluetooth for playback. Marshall's Bluetooth app provides some control over the speaker, but it's fairly basic.

You get three preset EQ modes—Marshall (default), Push (boosts bass and treble), and Voice (enhances mids for podcasts and calls). Unlike some competitors, there's no customisable EQ, which might be a downside for audiophiles looking to fine-tune their experience.

The Willen II also features a built-in microphone, allowing you to take calls directly from the speaker. Additionally, the 'Stack Mode' lets you link multiple Willen II speakers for a larger soundstage, though we couldn't test this feature due to a lack of additional units.

PERFORMANCE AND BATTERY LIFE

The Willen II houses a single 2-inch full-range driver and two passive radiators. Given its size, I wasn't expecting earth-shattering bass, and that expectation held true. The bass response is present but not particularly punchy. That being said, the mids and highs are where this speaker shines. Vocals and acoustic tracks sound crisp, with a balanced sound signature that works well across various genres.

Tracks like Hotel California by Eagles highlight the speaker's detailed treble reproduction, while Rescue Me by OneRepublic benefits from the well-defined mids. However, bass-heavy tracks like Uptown Funk by Bruno Mars feel a bit underwhelming, especially at lower volumes.

The volume output is decent for personal listening or small gatherings. It fills a room comfortably, but in open spaces, it lacks the power to compete with larger speakers. Distortion is